

POWERPLAY: OFFICIAL INSTRUCTION MANUAL

I. INITIAL PUBLIC OFFERING (GAME SETUP)

1. Establish Liquidity (The Supply)

- Create three distinct, easily accessible supply piles for the tokens: **Power (P)**, **Influence (IP)**, and **Coins (C)**. This is the central bank.
- **Coin Denominations:** The Coin supply should consist of 30 tokens of **1-value** and 20 tokens of **5-value**.

2. Prepare the Paperwork (The Decks)

- Separate the **Action Cards** into three distinct draw piles based on their Tier (T1, T2, T3). Shuffle each pile individually and place them face down.
 - **T1 Action Pile:** 4 unique cards × 3 copies = **12 cards total** (Free / 0 P Power Floor)
 - **T2 Action Pile:** 6 unique cards × 2 copies = **12 cards total** (1 IP / 1 P Power Floor)
 - **T3 Action Pile:** 5 unique cards × 2 copies = **10 cards total** (2 IP / 2 P Power Floor)
 - **Action Deck total:** 34 cards across 3 piles
- Separate the **Reaction Cards** into three distinct draw piles based on their Tier (T1, T2, T3). Shuffle each pile individually and place them face down.
 - **T1 Reaction Pile:** 5 unique cards × 2 copies = **10 cards total** (Free / 0 P Power Floor)
 - **T2 Reaction Pile:** 6 unique cards × 2 copies = **12 cards total** (1 IP / 1 P Power Floor)
 - **T3 Reaction Pile:** 5 unique cards × 2 copies = **10 cards total** (2 IP / 2 P Power Floor)
 - **Reaction Deck total:** 32 cards across 3 piles
- Shuffle the **Event Deck** (single pile, no tier separation). Place it face down.
 - **Event Deck:** 15 unique cards × 1 copy = **15 cards total**
- Separate the **Asset Cards** into three distinct draw piles based on their Tier (T1, T2, T3). Shuffle each pile individually and place them face down.
 - **T1 Asset Pile:** 8 unique cards × 2 copies = **16 cards total**
 - **T2 Asset Pile:** 8 unique cards × 2 copies = **16 cards total**
 - **T3 Asset Pile:** 5 unique cards × 2 copies = **10 cards total**

*Tier-pile structure for Action and Reaction decks follows the same pattern as Asset T1/T2/T3 piles. Power Floor (RC-Z14-01 Action, RC-Z15-01 Reaction) gates **all interactions** with tier piles — playing, drawing, and peeking — per RC-Z15-04 Tier Floor Universal Application.*

3. Determine the Market Leader (First Player Selection)

- The Board must establish dominance early. Players may collectively agree on *one* of the following metrics to determine who picks their Character first and takes the first turn:
 - **Liquid Assets:** Whoever currently has a physical \$100 bill on their person.
 - **Global Footprint:** Whoever went on a foreign trip most recently. (*Loophole: Any player currently visiting from a foreign country automatically wins this category.*)
 - **Depreciating Assets:** Whoever owns the most expensive car.
 - **Wearable Wealth:** Whoever is wearing the most expensive watch.
 - **The Power Move:** Whoever went to the toilet last.
- Place the **Leader Token** in front of the player selected based on the rules above.

4. The Org Chart (Character Selection & Starting Capital)

- Starting with the First Player and proceeding clockwise, players select one **Character** from the available roster.
 - **HR Addendum (The "Tom" Rule):** Anyone named "Tom" must pick their character *last*, regardless of the First Player metric. However, this penalty only applies to character selection; Tom retains their standard seat in the clockwise turn order.
- Once Characters are selected, each player collects their **Starting Stats** (Coins, Influence, and Power tokens) exactly as printed on their Character card.

5. Distribute Initial Portfolios (Starting Hands)

- Every player draws exactly **Three (3) T1 Action cards** (from the T1 Action Pile) and **Two (2) T1 Reaction cards** (from the T1 Reaction Pile) to form their starting hand. Keep these hidden.
- *Rationale: T1 cards are free to play and have no Power Floor, so every player can use their starting hand immediately regardless of Block. Higher-tier cards (T2/T3) must be drawn during play once the player meets the Power Floor for those piles. (RC-Z16-01)*

6. Commence Hostilities

- Turn order proceeds clockwise (to the left) starting from the First Player.

II. GLOSSARY OF TERMS (THE LEGAL FRAMEWORK)

- **Ability Lock:** When a player's Power drops below an Asset's Use Floor, that Asset's ability is locked — it cannot activate even if its trigger condition is met. Income still flows normally and Operating Costs must still be paid. The ability unlocks automatically when the player's Power meets or exceeds the Use Floor again.
- **Action Power Floor:** The minimum Power a player must hold to play an Action card of a given tier. **T1 = 0 P, T2 = 1 P, T3 = 2 P.** Power is checked, not spent — playing an Action does not reduce Power, but you cannot play a card of a tier above your current Power. **The same Power Floor applies to drawing and peeking Action cards of that tier,** per Tier Floor Universal Application (RC-Z15-04). (RC-Z14-01)
- **Attach:** A card persists on a target Asset (or player) until a condition is met or duration expires, then is discarded. **Default duration for Action card attachments: until the target/owner's next Conclude phase** (per RC-Z14-08). At each player's Conclude phase, remove any expired Attached cards from your Assets and from yourself. Cards may specify shorter durations explicitly (e.g., "next income roll, then discard") or use special trigger conditions. **Multiple Action attachments may exist on the same Asset simultaneously;** financial tokens (Loans, IOUs) follow their own one-per-asset constraint and are NOT cleared at Conclude.
- **Attacker:** Player who played the Action card.
- **Buy Floor:** The minimum Power a player must hold to draw from an Asset deck or bid on an Asset of that tier during the Pre-Market Auction or Brokerage. **T1 = 0 P, T2 = 1 P, T3 = 2 P** — aligned with Action Power Floor (RC-Z14-01), Reaction Power Floor (RC-Z15-01), and Asset Use Floor under one unified scheme. (RC-Z20-01 — *previously T2 = 2 P / T3 = 3 P; aligned in Z20.*) See also Tier Floor Universal Application (RC-Z15-04).
- **Bankrupt:** A state a player enters when they must pay Coins and cannot, even after liquidating all Assets. This results in player elimination.
- **Bonus Effect:** Optional additional effect requiring extra cost.
- **Cancel:** Stops an Action entirely.
- **Character Action:** A Free Action you may use during your turn. Cost is paid in IP or Power only (never Coins) as printed on the character card. Frequency: **once per round** (1 use across both of your turns in the round). (Updated Z19 to match `documents/characters.md` canonical frequency; supersedes earlier "once per turn" wording.)
- **Counter Tier-Up Rule:** A Reaction may Counter any Action of equal or lower tier. Specifically: **T1 Actions** can be Countered by T1, T2, or T3 Reactions; **T2 Actions** by T2 or T3 Reactions; **T3 Actions** by **T3 Reactions only**. Sacred Actions cannot be Countered by any means (see Sacred). (RC-Z14-03) **Fully active as of Z15.** The tier-up rule extends to all Reaction defensive effects targeting Actions — Counter, Prevent, Redirect, Cancel — per **Reaction Tier-Up Universal** (RC-Z15-02). **Reaction-vs-Reaction is tier-flat:** a Reaction of any tier may target a Reaction of any tier (no tier restriction between Reactions), per **Reaction-vs-Reaction Tier-Flat** (RC-Z15-03). Reaction chains are capped at 2 per Z10 chain rule.
- **Debt Settlement:** A sub-phase of Call-it-a-Night, between Currency Conversion and Thievery, where outstanding loans and IOUs are resolved. Sub-steps in order: (a) voluntary loan principal repayment; (b) loan maintenance fees due (1 C × active loans, except round of acquisition — grace round); (c) voluntary IOU repayment; (d) IOU negotiation between Defender and Attacker; (e) forced IOU liquidation if unpaid (Defender chooses an unencumbered Asset to liquidate; cascades through additional Assets if needed); (f) elimination only if IOUs unpaid AND no unencumbered Assets remain AND no negotiated agreement reached. (RC-Z14-06, RC-Z14-07)
- **Defender:** Player targeted by the Action.
- **Frozen:** A Frozen Asset and any attachments cannot be Used this turn.
- **Industry Synergy:** A conditional bonus on a card. Triggers if **the player who played the card** owns at least one Asset of the named Industry. The Industry of any target/attached Asset is irrelevant — only the playing player's own Asset portfolio matters. For Action cards, "the player who played the card" is the **Attacker**. For Reaction cards (Z15), it is the **player who played the Reaction**, which may or may not be the Defender. Card text format: `<Industry> Synergy: <effect>`. **Resource-impacting synergies appear only on T2 and T3 cards** (T1 cards are synergy-free per PR-Z14-C).

- **Information:** Private knowledge a player holds — such as the contents of their hand, their current resource totals, cards they have seen, or their future intentions. Information has no token representation but is a tradeable commodity.
- **IOU (Debt):** A deferred resource obligation **owed by one player to another (player ↔ player — the Defender owes the Attacker)**. Distinct from a Loan, which is player ↔ supply. When an Action card effect demands a resource the Defender lacks (insufficient IP, Power, or Coins), the Defender takes on a Coin-denominated IOU instead, held by the Attacker. **Conversion rates:** insufficient IP → 4 C per IP (3 + 1 interest); insufficient Power → 7 C per P (6 + 1 interest); insufficient Coin → (X+1) C. **Cap:** max 2 new IOUs per Defender per round (subsequent debt-triggers floor at 0). **Settlement:** at Call-it-a-Night Debt Settlement sub-phase. Defender may pay voluntarily or negotiate with Attacker (forgiveness, asset trades, etc.). If unpaid: Defender chooses an unencumbered Asset to liquidate (asset → discard, Defender receives printed cost from bank, pays Attacker MIN(IOU, available Coins); cascades through additional unencumbered Assets if IOU still unpaid). If no unencumbered Assets remain and no negotiated agreement reached, Defender is **eliminated from the game**. **Tradable** during CIAN trading. **Attacker elimination wipes their held IOUs.** (RC-Z14-06)
- **Lose:** A player reduces their Coins, Influence (IP), or Power (P). The card text will specify the amount and destination.
- **Loan (Corporate Debt):** Voluntary capital from the supply (player ↔ bank — no Attacker / Defender relationship; the bank is your counterparty). Loans are secured against an Asset (collateral). See § V "Action Phase" for the Take a Loan action. Loans are tracked as tokens attached to specific Assets — the Asset becomes Mortgaged. **Max 2 active loans per player** (checked at end of own Conclude phase; if exceeded, the player chooses one loan to default). **Maintenance fee:** 1 Coin per active loan, paid to supply at Call-it-a-Night, except in the round of acquisition (grace round). **Voluntary repayment** (free action during own Conclude or CIAN): pay principal + 1 Coin to clear; Asset unmortgaged. **Loan default** (missed maintenance, max-2-violation, or end-of-game CTB): attached Asset → discard pile; bank pays the player printed cost; the player pays loan dues (principal + 1 C) to bank; the player keeps the surplus (= printed cost – principal – 1; 1 C / 3 C / 6 C for T1/T2/T3). Loan discharged. **No elimination from loan default** (in contrast to IOU default — IOUs are player-to-player; see IOU glossary entry). (RC-Z14-07)
- **PowerPlay!:** A Sacred Free Action in which the active player pays **1 Power** to gain **+1 Standard Action** for the current turn AND draws **1 Action card and 1 Reaction card**. Once per turn.
- **PR Bonus (Public Relations):** When you play a card, trigger an Asset ability, or draw an Event card, you may read the Humor text aloud. If any other player audibly reacts, gain +1 Coin from the supply.
- **Prevent:** Blocks a specific effect (loss or damage).
- **Redirect:** Sends an Action's effect to another player.
- **Reaction:** A card played from the hand at any time, out of turn sequence, in response to an Action, another Reaction, or an Event. Reactions may be played to protect yourself or another player (and their Assets). Reaction cards are the primary exception to turn-based play. **The player who plays a Reaction is the Reactor** (see Reactor entry). Reactions are organized in three tiers (T1/T2/T3) with corresponding Power Floor gates and cost structure (see Reaction Power Floor). Reactions targeting other Reactions are tier-flat (no tier-up restriction between Reactions); see Counter Tier-Up Rule. Industry Synergies on T2/T3 Reactions trigger on the Reactor's owned Assets, not the protected player's.
- **Reaction Power Floor:** The minimum Power a player must hold to play, draw, or peek a Reaction card of a given tier. **T1 = 0 P, T2 = 1 P, T3 = 2 P**. Power is checked, not spent — parallel to Action Power Floor (RC-Z14-01). The Reaction deck is physically separated into T1, T2, and T3 piles; players may only interact with piles whose Floor they meet. (RC-Z15-01) See also Tier Floor Universal Application (RC-Z15-04).
- **Reactor:** The player who plays a Reaction card. The Reactor may defend themselves or any other player (the "target player"). The Reactor is **not necessarily** the Defender — any player at the table may play a Reaction in response to an Action, Reaction, or Event affecting any other player. For Reaction Industry Synergies, the **Reactor's** owned Assets are checked, not the protected player's (per PR-Z14-D extended for Reactions). (Codified Z15.)
- **Resource Flow Notation:** Card text follows a consistent vocabulary for resource movement. **gain X** = receive from supply (no transfer between players). **lose X** = lose to supply (no transfer). **pay X to [player]** = direct transfer from one player to another. **take X from [player] / steal X from [player]** = transfer from named player to playing player. Default: when a card says "Attacker gains +Y" without specifying a source, the resource comes from the supply. When it says "Defender loses Y" without specifying a destination, the resource goes to the supply. (PR-Z14-I)
- **Refuse:** The Defender ignores the Action but suffers its Refusal Penalty. **(Deprecated for Action cards as of RC-Z14-05 — no current Action card has a Refusal Penalty. The Defender's only counterplay against an Action is Counter via Reaction. Mechanic preserved for potential future card types.)**
- **Sacred:** A class of actions, abilities, or effects that cannot be Cancelled, Countered, Prevented, or Redirected by any means (Reactions, asset abilities, character abilities, or any other source). PowerPlay! is Sacred. Specific character abilities may grant Sacred status to a designated play (see character cards). (RC-Z13-05, clarified Z19 as RC-Z19-01)
- **Replace:** Discard 1 card of the specified type (e.g., Action) from your hand to draw 1 new card of that same type from its deck.

- **Sell:** As 1 of your actions during your Action Phase, you may Sell one Asset you own. You may sell to the bank (return the Asset card to the supply and gain Coins equal to its printed cost) or to another player (they pay you the printed cost and receive the Asset).
- **Signing Bonus:** A one-time resource grant the buyer gains the moment they acquire an Asset via **voluntary acquisition** (Pre-Market Auction, Brokerage, or consensual trade). The bonus is printed on the Asset card and uniform within each tier: **T1 Assets have no Signing Bonus** (RC-Z13-01); **T2 Assets grant "Gain 1 IP"** (RC-Z13-02); **T3 Assets grant "Gain 1 Power"** (RC-Z13-03). The Signing Bonus applies once only — at acquisition. **The Signing Bonus does NOT apply to forced or hostile transfers (e.g., Hostile Takeover)** (RC-Z14-04).
- **Starting Hand:** At setup, every player draws exactly **3 T1 Action cards** (from the T1 Action Pile) and **2 T1 Reaction cards** (from the T1 Reaction Pile). T1 cards are free to play and have no Power Floor, so every player can use their starting hand immediately regardless of Block. Higher-tier cards (T2/T3) must be drawn during play once the player meets the Power Floor for those piles. See § I.5. (RC-Z16-01)
- **T1 Asset Resource Discipline:** T1 Asset abilities may grant Coins or information; their **primary effect** may not directly grant Influence (IP) or Power. Exception: GENERATOR-category T1 Assets may grant Power via their **GENERATOR Bonus** clause. (RC-Z13-04)
- **Tier Floor Universal Application:** The Power Floor for each tier of Action and Reaction card applies to **all interactions** with cards of that tier: playing, drawing (from the tier pile during Initiate Phase or Brokerage), and peeking (via card abilities or effects). Specifically: **T1 piles = 0 P, T2 piles = 1 P, T3 piles = 2 P**. Power is checked, not spent. The Action deck and Reaction deck are each physically separated into T1, T2, and T3 piles for this purpose. The Asset Buy Floor and Asset Use Floor use the **same values** (RC-Z20-01) — one unified Power-Floor scheme across every tier interaction in the game. (RC-Z15-04, aligned to RC-Z20-01.) See Action Power Floor (RC-Z14-01), Reaction Power Floor (RC-Z15-01), Buy Floor, Use Floor.
- **Trigger:** An automatic ability that occurs when a specific game condition is met. The player does not spend an Action to make it happen.
- **Use:** Activate an Asset's ability or generate its income.
- **Use Floor:** The minimum Power a player must hold to activate an Asset's ability. T1 = 0 P, T2 = 1 P, T3 = 2 P. If a player's Power drops below the Use Floor, the ability is locked (see Ability Lock). Power is checked, not spent.

III. THE ROUND STRUCTURE

A standard Round of PowerPlay consists of three distinct phases, representing a complete fiscal quarter.

1. Inception Phase

- **Market Shock:** Draw exactly **One (1) Universal Event** card and resolve its effects immediately. *If the Event deck is empty, shuffle its discard pile to form a new draw pile first, then draw.* Event cards are active for the round if they have effects that affect players during their turns or when they take actions; one-shot effects (e.g., immediate losses) resolve during Inception and then end; ongoing effects (e.g., income modifiers, cost changes) remain in effect until Call-it-a-Night.
- **The Pre-Market (Asset Auction):**
 1. In turn order, starting with the Leader, the active player chooses one Asset Deck (T1, T2, or T3) and draws the top card. This card is placed face-up in the center of the table. **Power Gate:** A player may only draw from a deck they meet the Buy Floor for (T1 = 0 P, T2 = 1 P, T3 = 2 P, per RC-Z20-01).
 2. Once a card is drawn, it immediately goes up for public auction. Bidding occurs clockwise, starting with the player to the left of the person who drew the card.
 - **Bidding Rules:** When it is your turn to bid, you may choose to **pass** (not bid), or place a bid. **You may only bid on an Asset if you meet its Buy Floor.**
 - **The Bid Range:** The minimum starting bid is **1 Coin**. You may bid any amount of Coins up to your current liquid total (you cannot bid more Coins than you currently possess). Subsequent bids must be higher than the current leading bid.
 3. The player who originally drew the card always bids *last*, giving them the ultimate choice to outbid the table or let the asset go.
 4. The highest bidder pays their bid amount to the bank and acquires the Asset. If all players pass and there are no bids, the card is discarded.
 5. Once the first card is resolved, the next player in clockwise order draws a card from an Asset deck of their choice, and the auction process repeats. This continues until every player has drawn and auctioned exactly one card. The Pre-Market then closes.

2. Opening Bell (Player Turns)

- During this phase, all players take **two turns**.
- The sequence of turns proceeds clockwise starting from the **First Player** (the player holding the Leader Token).
- Once every player has taken their first turn, the sequence immediately resets back to the **First Player** to begin the second pass around the table.
- In **Blitz Mode** only, the second turn in each round is called the **Market Reversal**: turn order reverses — the last player to take their first turn goes first in the second pass, then players proceed counter-clockwise (to the right), so the Leader plays last before Call-it-a-Night.
- A player's turn consists of three sub-phases: **Initiate**, **Action**, and **Conclude**.

3. Call-it-a-Night (End of Round)

Once every player has completed their **second** Conclude phase, the Round enters the Call-it-a-Night phase:

- **The Earnings Call & Corporate Espionage**: Players may openly brag about their current wealth, status, or achievements. **Player Trading**: During this specific window, players may freely trade resources (Coins, IP, Power), Assets, and IOUs with each other. Trades are binding.
 - **Currency Conversion**: Players may freely convert Tokens at the standard exchange rates (3 Coins = 1 Influence | 2 Influence = 1 Power).
 - **Debt Settlement** (RC-Z14-06, RC-Z14-07): Resolve all outstanding loans and IOUs in this order:
 - (a) **Voluntary loan principal repayment** (free action) — pay off any loans you wish to clear; their attached Assets unmortgage immediately.
 - (b) **Loan maintenance fees due** — 1 Coin per active loan paid to supply, except in the round of acquisition (grace round). Defaulting on missed maintenance: attached Asset → discard, bank pays printed cost to the player, the player pays loan dues, the player keeps surplus (per Loan glossary entry — Loans are player → supply, not player ↔ player).
 - (c) **Voluntary IOU repayment** — pay IOUs in Coins to the holders.
 - (d) **IOU negotiation** — Defender and Attacker (or current IOU holder) may negotiate forgiveness, partial payment, asset trades, or future favors. Any agreement resolves the IOU.
 - (e) **Forced IOU liquidation** (if any IOU still unpaid): Defender chooses one of their **unencumbered Assets** (no loan or other token attached) to liquidate. Asset → discard pile. Bank pays Defender printed cost in Coins; Defender pays Attacker MIN(IOU, available Coins). If IOU still unpaid, Defender chooses another unencumbered Asset and repeats. **Loans cannot be taken during forced liquidation** — only existing assets count.
 - (f) **Elimination**: If a Defender has unpaid IOUs AND no unencumbered Assets remain AND no negotiated agreement is reached, the Defender is **eliminated from the game**. Their owed IOUs and any held IOUs are wiped.
 - **Thievery**: If the player with the *lowest* total Power is not already the 1st Player, they must steal the **Leader Token** and assign it to any player of their choice — including themselves. *If multiple players are tied for lowest Power, the player among them who is earliest in turn order must make the assignment.*
 - *If this is not the final round, a new Round begins with the Inception Phase.*
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IV. TURN STRUCTURE (THE OPENING BELL)

When it is your turn, you must complete the following phases in order:

A. Initiate Phase

- **Draw**: Draw one card of your choice (Action OR Reaction) **from a tier pile you meet the Power Floor for** (per RC-Z15-04 Tier Floor Universal Application). T1 piles are accessible to all players (0 P Floor); T2 piles require 1 P; T3 piles require 2 P. *If the chosen pile is empty, shuffle its discard pile to form a new draw pile, then draw. Note: You have an infinite maximum hand size during your turn until the Conclude phase.*
- **Collect Revenue**: Roll a 1d6 to determine market strength on the Fiscal Table and collect the corresponding income in Coins for all active, unfrozen Assets you own.
 - **Portfolio Diversification**: Roll a separate 1d6 for each Tier of Asset you own.
 - **The Lobbyist Reroll**: You may pay **2 Coins** to reroll any one of your income dice. *(Note: This ability does not have synergy bonuses).*

- **Operating Costs (Tax):** Each T2 Asset you own requires an upkeep of **1 Coin**, and each T3 Asset requires **2 Coins**. Deduct this total from your income payout before collecting. (T1 Assets have no upkeep).
- **Forced Bankruptcy:** If your total income after deducting Operating Costs results in a negative balance that you cannot pay from your reserves, you must immediately enter Bankruptcy Resolution before proceeding to Market Operations.
- **Market Operations (Private Brokerage):** During this phase, you may perform **one** free Market Operation before your Action Phase begins. Choose one:
 - **Broker an Asset Deal:** Pay a Brokerage Fee (1 Coin for T1, 2 Coins for T2, 3 Coins for T3) to draw the top **two** cards from *one specific* Asset Deck you meet the **Buy Floor** for (T1 = 0 P, T2 = 1 P, T3 = 2 P, per RC-Z20-01). You may purchase exactly one of those cards at its printed cost. The other is discarded. *No other players may buy assets during your turn.*
 - **Buy an Action Card:** Pay 1 Coin to the supply to draw the top card of an **Action tier pile you meet the Power Floor** for (T1 = 0 P, T2 = 1 P, T3 = 2 P; per RC-Z15-04).
 - **Buy a Reaction Card:** Pay 2 Coins to the supply to draw the top card of a **Reaction tier pile you meet the Power Floor** for (T1 = 0 P, T2 = 1 P, T3 = 2 P; per RC-Z15-04).

B. Action Phase

You may perform exactly **One (1) Standard Action** per turn. Since Market purchasing now happens in the Initiate Phase, the Action Phase is strictly for maneuvers and corporate warfare. *(Note: Action cards, or specific Asset triggers may grant additional actions — e.g., via Events or the Investment Bank. When a source grants +1 Action, your budget increases even if you have already spent your standard action; you may then take another.)* Choose one of the following:

- **Play an Action Card:** Play one Action card from your hand, pay its cost, and resolve its effects. *You cannot play an Action card that targets a player who has no valid targets for that card (e.g., Hostile Takeover requires the target to own at least one T1 or T2 Asset).*
- **Sell an Asset:** Liquidate an Asset you own to the bank for its exact printed cost. *(Note: You can no longer directly sell an asset to another player during the Action phase; all trades occur during Call-It-A-Night).*
- **Corporate Debt (Take a Loan):** Take a loan from the supply against one of your Assets for half its printed cost (rounded down). The Asset becomes Mortgaged (loan token attached). *Terms (RC-Z14-07): **Max 2 active loans per player** — checked at end of own Conclude phase; if you finish with 3+ loans, you must default one (chosen by you). **Maintenance fee: 1 Coin per active loan, paid to supply at Call-it-a-Night**, except in the round you took the loan (grace round). **Voluntary repayment** anytime during your own Conclude phase or CIAN (free action): pay principal + 1 Coin → Asset unmortgaged. **No fixed term — loans persist until repaid voluntarily, defaulted on missed maintenance, or force-resolved at end-game Clean-the-Books.** A mortgaged asset still earns income and can use its ability. An asset with an active loan token cannot be used to secure another loan or attach an IOU. **Loan default mechanic:** attached Asset → discard pile; bank pays you the printed cost; you pay loan dues (principal + 1 Coin) back to bank; you keep the surplus (1 C / 3 C / 6 C for T1/T2/T3). Loan discharged. No elimination from loan default.*
- **Skip:** Do nothing and take 2 Coins from the supply as a consulting fee.

Free Actions (Do not consume your Standard Action):

- **Take a Character Action:** Use your unique Character Ability. You must still pay the required Resource cost (IP or Power as printed on the card; never Coins). You may only use your Character Action **once per round** (1 use across both of your turns in the round).
- **PowerPlay!:** Pay **1 Power** to gain **+1 Standard Action** this turn AND draw **1 Action card and 1 Reaction card**. You may only use PowerPlay! **once per turn**. *(Sacred)*

C. Conclude Phase

- **Filing Deadlines:** Discard your hand down to exactly **3 Action Cards** and **2 Reaction Cards**. *(Hand limits are fixed at 3A/2R for all player counts.)*
- **Voluntary Loan Repayment (RC-Z14-07):** You may pay off any of your Loans (principal + 1 Coin) — Asset unmortgages.
- **Loan Cap Check (RC-Z14-07):** At end-of-Conclude, you must hold no more than **2 active loans**. If you finish Conclude with 3+ loans (e.g., took a 3rd as your Action and didn't pay one off), choose one loan to default; that loan resolves per the Loan default mechanic (attached Asset → discard, surplus to you).
- **Attach Cleanup (RC-Z14-08):** Remove any expired Attached cards from your Assets and from yourself. Most Action card attachments expire at this point unless they specify a different duration.
- **Unfreeze Assets:** All of your frozen Assets are unfrozen at the end of your Conclude phase.

D. PR Bonus (Public Relations)

When a player plays an Action card, plays a Reaction card, uses a Character Ability, triggers an Asset ability, or draws an Event card, they may read that card's Humor text aloud to all players. If any other player audibly reacts (laughs, groans, claps, etc.), the reader gains **+1 Coin** from the supply.

V. FISCAL TIMELINE & GAME MODES

THE STANDARD FISCAL CYCLE (6 Rounds)

- **Player Count:** Requires **3 to 5 players**. The game does not support fewer than 3 or more than 5 active seats. Any additional participants must join as **spectators only**.
- **Duration:** The game concludes at the end of the 6th *Call-it-a-Night* phase. With two turns per round, this provides 12 total turns — enough for the Loan mechanic and high-yield Tier 3 Assets to pay off while keeping the pace brisk.

ALTERNATE BOARD RESOLUTIONS

- **The Blitz Mode (4 Rounds):** Highly recommended for 5 players. Silicon Valley pacing. During Blitz, the second turn in each round is the **Market Reversal**: turn order reverses counter-clockwise so the Leader plays last before Call-it-a-Night. Taking a loan late in the game is a massive liability. Players must rely on aggressive Action cards and rapid asset flipping.
 - **Long-Term Investment (8 Rounds):** Highly recommended for 3 players. A classic wealth-building cycle designed for players who want to construct massive, interlocking portfolios and weather multiple crashes from the Event deck.
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VI. CLEAN THE BOOKS

Before the Board Meeting can begin, the board must be perceived as beyond reproach. After the final Call-it-a-Night phase, **all players must immediately settle every outstanding loan** (RC-Z14-07).

- **Forced Repayment:** Each player chooses for each outstanding Loan: either pay (principal + 1 Coin) to discharge the Loan and unmortgage the Asset, OR allow the Loan to default per the Loan default mechanic (attached Asset → discard, bank pays printed cost, player pays loan dues, player keeps surplus).
 - **No new loans may be taken during Clean the Books.**
 - **Order:** Debts are resolved in turn order, one player at a time.
 - **No elimination from loan default at CTB** — every loan can be discharged via voluntary payment OR default. Loan default never causes elimination. (*Elimination from financial pressure happens only via IOU forced liquidation in CIAN per RC-Z14-06, not via end-game loan resolution.*)
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VII. THE BOARD MEETING (END GAME SCORING)

When Clean the Books concludes, players must liquidate their empires and calculate their Total Power to determine the winner.

The Final Valuation Formula: $\text{Total Power} = (\text{Power Tokens}) + \text{floor}(\text{Influence} / 2) + \text{floor}(\text{Coins} / 6) + \text{floor}(\text{Total Asset Value} / 5)$ (Note: Always round down. The board does not reward fractions of a success).

The Board values a **diversified portfolio** over a fat checking account. Liquid Coins score at $\text{floor}(C / 6)$ while owned Assets score at $\text{floor}(\text{Asset Value} / 5)$ — because cash on hand is for amateurs and the post-IPO market wants to see your moves on the cap table, not your savings. (**RC-REF1-01, 2026-05-12**) — supersedes the earlier $\text{floor}(C / 5)$ term.

The player with the most Total Power is declared the **POWER PLAYER**.

Tie-Breaker Protocol: In the event of a tie, corporate litigation is settled via a Best-of-3 match of **Rock, Paper, Scissors, Lizard, Spock**.



VIII. INFORMATION IS POWER (INTEL TRADING)

In PowerPlay, information is a valuable commodity. Players may trade **Information for resources** with any other player **at any time** — during their own turn, during another player's turn, or between phases. No action is spent to initiate a trade.

What counts as Information:

- Revealing one or more cards from your hand (Action or Reaction cards)
- Disclosing your current resource totals (Coins, Influence, Power)
- Sharing knowledge of cards you have seen (e.g., via Character Abilities, Asset effects, etc.)
- Revealing your intentions, plans, or strategy

The Deal: Players negotiate freely. Either party may propose the exchange. Terms — what information is revealed and what resources change hands — are decided entirely by mutual agreement. There is no fixed rate.

Binding vs. Non-Binding: The information exchange itself (revealing or sharing) and any immediate resource payment are binding the moment both parties agree. Any *future* promises attached to a deal (e.g., "I won't target you next round") are **verbal and non-binding** — PowerPlay does not enforce future commitments.

Bankruptcy

If a player enters a **negative balance**, they have until the **next Conclude phase of their turn** to recover:

- **If they go negative on their own turn:** They have until the Conclude phase of that same turn to resolve the debt.
- **If they go negative on another player's turn** (e.g., from an Event, Reaction, or another player's Action): They have until the Conclude phase of their **next** turn to resolve the debt.

During that window, the player must:

1. Sell Assets to regain a positive balance
2. Attempt trades with other players
3. Take a Loan against an asset for half its cost (the loan comes due in 2 rounds during the Conclude phase of their turn)

If the player **liquidates all assets and remains negative** by the end of their recovery window, they must either:

- Secure funding from another player
 - Take a loan (if they still have assets to collateralise)
 - Exit the game (elimination)
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Appendix: Resolved Design Questions

The following design questions have been formally resolved and are reflected in the rules above:

ID	Question	Resolution
OQ-001	Bankruptcy recovery window	Until the next Conclude phase of the bankrupt player's turn. If negative on their own turn → that Conclude phase; if negative on another player's turn → their next turn's Conclude phase.
OQ-006	Hand size by player count	Fixed at 3 Action cards and 2 Reaction cards for all player counts. During setup, each player draws 3 Action + 2 Reaction.
OQ-007	Actions per turn	1 Standard Action per turn. Two turns per round gives sufficient action opportunities.
OQ-008	Character Action slot	Character Action is a Free Action limited to once per round (1 use across both of your turns in the round, per <code>documents/characters.md</code> canonical frequency, Z19-clarified). It does not consume the 1 Standard Action.